

5 Appendices

5.1 Before you begin hacking

There is a sense of satisfaction in getting software to do something its author never intended or perhaps even imagined. Needless to say this also means you are going into untested territory – and while there is a charm in that – it can end up crashing your system and exposing bugs. Before you go messing about with your computer, it is a good idea to have a recovery plan. If you use Windows make sure you have the System Restore / System Protection turned on. Windows XP, Vista and 7 discs include a recovery mode that can be activated in case of any problems.

In Windows XP you can install the recovery console to your hard disk if you choose. This way you can easily access the recovery console without the long loading times when running it from the CD. The following steps will guide you how to install the recovery console on your hard disk:

- Insert the Windows XP disk into your disk drive
- Click on **Start** > **Run** or press the [Windows] + [R] to launch the run dialog.
- In the run dialog enter `X:\i386\winnt32.exe /cmdcons` (replace X with your disc drive letter).
- Follow the instructions on screen.

If you are using Windows Vista or 7, you might already have the recovery console installed on the hard disk. In this case you will find a “Repair your computer” option when you press [F8] while starting your computer. If you don’t see this option, you can still boot from the Windows DVD and choose the **Repair your computer** option. In this case it is better to create a bootable pendrive with the Windows Vista / Windows 7 installer. If you have a Windows Vista or Windows 7 disc, you might prefer to use the recovery console provided with that, as it is more powerful and will come in handy.

To create a Windows Vista / 7 bootable installation pendrive, you will need a 4GB pendrive. Once you have one, follow the steps below. Since this book is aimed to enlighten you as much as possible, we will describe what we are doing here and the command line tools and options even though it is slightly tangential.

- **Connect the pendrive, and format it in NTFS**

This step is important because the Windows Vista or Windows 7 setup can only be booted from an NTFS drive. If you are using Windows XP, you will not see an NTFS option while formatting pendrives. Use a Vista / Windows 7 system or the bootable DVD.